

man / --help discoverability

You will not memorize every flag

Four ways to ask for help

- Use `man` when you want the full manual page for a command
- Use a help flag, often two dashes `help`, when you need a short usage reminder
- Use `whatis` for a one-line summary of what a command is
- Use `apropos` when you remember the idea but not the command name
- Pick the lightest tool that answers your question, then go back to work

Browser lab

Digital Design and Verification Platform

HomeTools

Home / Tools / Help

Quiz: manQuiz: --helpQuiz: whatisQuiz: aproposman lsSpace pageSearch recursiveq quitls --helpcp --helpwhatis cpwhatis lsapropos copyapropos permissionman -kQuiz: section 1Quiz: man vs helpman grepwhatis multimake --helpQuiz: quit keyDiscover find

Lab terminal

Starter: try man ls · then ls --help · whatis cp · apropos copy

Space ↓b ↑/ searchn nextq quit

lab\$ man · --help · whatis · apropos

ready

Catalog topics

ls cp mv grep find pwd mkdir makegit chmod

- man TOPIC — full page (Space / b /// q)
- TOPIC --help — short usage
- whatis TOPIC — one-line NAME
- apropos KEYWORD or man -k KEYWORD

When to use what

Goal	Command
Full manual + examples	man command
Quick flag reminder	command --help
What does this command do?	command --help

man / --help lab starter

Real shell practice

```
wsl - module02-man-help-lab/examples/help

# Track A - real Unix
# real shell session (Track A)

$ whatis ls
ls... (1)          - list directory contents

$ ls --help | head -n 12
Usage: ls [OPTION]... [FILE]...
List information about the FILES (the current directory by default).
Sort entries alphabetically if none of -cftuvSUX nor --sort is specified.

Mandatory arguments to long options are mandatory for short options too.
-a, --all                do not ignore entries starting with .
-A, --almost-all        do not list implied . and ..
--author                with -l, print the author of each file
-b, --escape             print C-style escapes for nongraphic characters
--block-size=SIZE       with -l, scale sizes by SIZE when printing them;
                        e.g., '--block-size=M'; see SIZE format below
-B, --ignore-backups    do not list implied entries ending with ~

$ MANPAGER=cat man ls | head -n 20
LS(1)                                User Commands                                LS(1)

NAME
    ls - list directory contents

SYNOPSIS
    ls [OPTION]... [FILE]...

DESCRIPTION
    List information about the FILES (the current directory
    by default). Sort entries alphabetically if none of -cf-
    tuvSUX nor --sort is specified.

    Mandatory arguments to long options are mandatory for
    short options too.

    -a, --all
        do not ignore entries starting with .

    -A, --almost-all
```

Real shell — man and help

Real shell practice — try these

```
# whatis — one-line summary of a command  
whatis ls
```

```
# ls --help — short usage / flags; head keeps the first lines  
ls --help | head -n 12
```

```
# man — full manual; MANPAGER=cat prints instead of interactive pager  
MANPAGER=cat man ls | head -n 20
```

Pitfalls to watch

- Not every command has a man page on every machine
- Some tools use a help flag; others use a different switch
- Interactive man viewers need a quit key, or they feel “stuck.” And remember

Your turn

- Complete the checklist for at least one track, preferably both
- In the browser, finish a few challenges after the starter
- On the real shell, run through the help example
- When you are ready, take the short quiz, then continue to absolute versus relative paths